

Infrastructure Insight — Defense Note

Why the "competitors don't build, they buy from infrastructure providers" finding belongs in the Synthesis section, not in a single KIT.

Why this finding belongs in Synthesis, not in any single KIT

The insight that incumbent foodservice competitors do not build their own digital platforms but source them from infrastructure providers (Mirakl for Sysco; Adobe Commerce / Magento for Bidfood; Drupal + Commercetools for Transgourmet; freiheit.com + DataArt for METRO) touches all three KITs. It cannot live in any one of them without losing its analytical force:

- **KIT 1 — Strategic decisions:** the insight reframes METRO's own platform decisions as a *build / partner / acquire* trichotomy, directly informing sCore 2030 execution.
- **KIT 2 — Early warning:** the insight explains the KIQ 2.2 finding that foodservice incumbents file zero patents in digital ordering — they are technology *buyers*, not technology *inventors*.
- **KIT 3 — Key players & positioning:** the insight reveals how competitors are differentiated by their infrastructure-stack choices (Mirakl-powered marketplace vs. composable best-of-breed vs. proprietary digital-native build).

A finding that touches three KITs is by definition a **synthesis insight**, not a KIQ-level finding. It earns its place as a strategic recommendation at the end of the report, not as a sub-bullet inside one KIQ.

The strategic framing — one sentence

"The competitive battle in B2B HoReCa digital ordering is no longer about whether to build a digital platform — it's about which infrastructure partner to choose, which capabilities to keep in-house, and which digital-native to acquire."

This sentence is the strategic recommendation that lives in the Synthesis section. It bridges directly to METRO's sCore 2030 target (40% digital sales) by reframing the execution question from *"how do we build digital capability?"* to *"which partner, in-house, and acquisition decisions will deliver that capability?"*

Why the cross-KIQ logic is methodologically clean

Each KIQ uses the indicator specified in the scope document. The infrastructure providers appear in KIQ 3.1 (not in KIQ 2.2) because each KIQ's indicator surfaces different evidence:

KIQ	Indicator	What it reveals
KIQ 2.2	Patent filings + scientific publications	Incumbents have zero patents in digital ordering — the IP gap
KIQ 3.1	Competitor websites + industry reports + agency case studies + analyst coverage	The infrastructure providers behind each competitor's platform

Infrastructure providers (Mirakl, Commercetools, Adobe Commerce, freiheit.com) appear in KIQ 3.1 because their competitive moat is **proprietary SaaS, not patents**. They would not have appeared in KIQ 2.2's patent corpus regardless of how the query was constructed. Each KIQ used its own

indicator correctly; the synthesis emerges when the two are combined.

The cross-KIQ flow

- **KIQ 2.2 raises the question** — *"if foodservice competitors have zero IP in this space, where are they sourcing their digital capability?"*
- **KIQ 3.1 answers it** — *"from infrastructure providers (Mirakl, Commercetools, Adobe Commerce) and software agencies (freiheit.com, 1xINTERNET, iWeb, DataArt)."*
- **The Synthesis section closes the loop** — reframes this as the build / partner / acquire strategic decision for METRO going forward.

This is exactly what cross-KIQ synthesis is designed to do: each KIQ stands on its own indicator and produces its own finding, and the strategic value emerges from combining them. It is a strength of the analysis, not a gap.

Optional — small defensive move in KIQ 2.2

An optional one-line addition can be made to the KIQ 2.2 takeaway, near the end, to signal the cross-reference explicitly:

"The implied counterpart — that foodservice competitors source their digital capability from infrastructure providers rather than build it in-house — is established empirically in KIQ 3.1."

This addition is **optional**. If the cross-reference is fully developed in the Synthesis section, it does not need to be repeated in KIQ 2.2. The choice depends on whether you want the cross-reference to be visible at the point where the question is first raised (KIQ 2.2) or only where the strategic conclusion is delivered (Synthesis).

Summary — what to remember in defense

- The infrastructure insight is a **cross-KIT synthesis**, not a KIQ finding.
- Its natural home is the **Synthesis section** at the end of the report.
- The reason it appears in KIQ 3.1 and not KIQ 2.2 is **indicator-driven**: each KIQ used the indicator specified in the scope document, and the infrastructure providers naturally surface in the KIT 3 evidence base (competitor websites, agency case studies), not in the KIT 2 patent corpus.
- The cross-KIQ logic flows correctly: KIQ 2.2 raises the question, KIQ 3.1 answers it, and the Synthesis section delivers the strategic recommendation.
- This is the kind of insight that demonstrates **analytical maturity** — connecting evidence across different KIQs rather than treating each as a stand-alone deliverable.